

MOSIP 1.0: The Open Source Identity Platform for Governments

When a leading Indian tech institute, backed by respected global funding partners, releases a new open source identity platform, it calls for celebrations. MOSIP 1.0 was released this February at Bengaluru. Here's a brief description of the event.



In order to mark the release of the foundational identity project, MOSIP 1.0 (Modular Open Source Identity Platform, <https://mosip.io>), the International Institute of Information Technology Bangalore (IIIT-B) organised the 'MOSIP Open Source Day' on February 14, at the Samsung Opera House in Bengaluru.

The day marked a significant milestone in what has been an eventful journey and a profound learning experience of close to two years with innumerable people contributing to code, tests, documentation and interactions with experts and organisations, around the world.

MOSIP was conceived as a response to the challenges facing countries that have tried to adopt large scale digital identity platforms for better delivery of services. It is a technology platform that helps governments and other user organisations implement a digital, foundational identity system. Nations can use MOSIP freely to build their own identity systems. Being modular in its architecture, MOSIP provides flexibility to countries in how they implement and configure their systems, and helps avoid vendor lock-in. The open source approach makes it possible for MOSIP to become the go-to digital ID platform for development and review by experts from around the world, particularly when incorporating state-of-art security and privacy technologies. The code is available in its entirety at <https://github.com/mosip> under the Mozilla Public License 2.0.

Anchored at the IIIT-B as a global digital public good, and funded by the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, Omidyar Network and Tata Trusts, MOSIP presents a different way of approaching the architecture, design and integration of

large scale systems — one that recognises foundational ID as a strategic asset of a country. It focuses on one thing — the means to empower every resident with a unique identity, which they can use to authenticate themselves.

On Open Source Day, the keynote speech was given by Dame Wendy Hall, who is Regius Professor of Computer Science at the University of Southampton, UK. Dame Wendy, with Sir Tim Berners-Lee and Sir Nigel Shadbolt, co-founded the Web Science Research Initiative in 2006. She is the executive director of the Web Science Trust, and was co-chair of the UK government's AI Review, which was published in October 2017. Recently, the UK government announced that Dame Hall is the first Skills Champion for AI in the UK.

Dame Wendy spoke about the geopolitics of data governance and the Internet, and the diverging directions taken by the United States, Europe, China and Russia. She highlighted the importance of approaches taken in India with respect to digital governance, as people begin to come online in the rural parts of China, India and Africa. Projects such as MOSIP could be a force for good and not for harm, in this scenario, as long as those behind it realise the responsibilities it bears.

The second guest, Edith Orcilla of the Philippine Statistics Authority, shared her experiences and progress in building the Philippine Identification System, or PhilSys. She discussed the approach and thinking that had led the government of Philippines to use an open system such as MOSIP, and the technological and governance choices of the project so far.

From the MOSIP team, Prof. Rajagopalan, the faculty coordinator for MOSIP, talked about how MOSIP came to be built, the technological approaches of the project and the learnings so far. Puneet Joshi from the team shared highlights from the platform's roadmap. There was also a Q&A session convened by Prof. Rajagopalan and Ramesh Narayanan from the MOSIP team.

The evening ended on a special note as the MOSIP team thanked and felicitated over 30 people who had made incredibly valuable contributions to the development of the platform.

The event was live streamed, and the video can be viewed on the MOSIP website at <https://www.mosip.io/news-events/watch-the-livestream-open-source-day-february-14-2020>. **END** 🐧

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